The Historical Jesus: An Evidentiary Reassessment

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Abstract

The historicity of Jesus of Nazareth is treated as settled in mainstream New Testament scholarship. This paper argues that the confidence is unwarranted. Drawing on a corpus-linguistic baseline study of 212 *adelphos* tokens across six non-Christian Greek corpora, an inscriptional survey of Greek religious-association usage of *adelphoi tou* [patron] (Harland 2005), a text-critical and stylometric analysis of the Pauline passages historically adduced against mythic-origin accounts, and a Bayesian sensitivity analysis that implements source-dependency in the cumulative case, I argue that (i) the Pauline corpus describes a revelatory celestial figure assembled from pre-Christian Jewish apocalyptic-mystical sources; (ii) the principal Pauline evidence traditionally cited against mythic-origin scenarios, while non-trivial, is textually secure and therefore not susceptible to interpolation arguments; (iii) the Gospels are not independent historical testimony but literary constructions from Hebrew Bible templates; (iv) the non-Christian attestation is weaker than claimed and largely dependent on early Christian informants; and (v) under plausible assumptions the posterior probability of historicity lands in open-question rather than settled territory. The responsible conclusion is that the question is genuinely contested and that the scholarly consensus is sustained in part by institutional and methodological inertia. Full evidence and supplementary material are available in a companion full-length treatment.

Keywords: historical Jesus, mythicism, Pauline epistles, corpus linguistics, *adelphos tou kyriou*, Jewish apocalyptic mysticism, Bayesian historiography.

1 Introduction

Does the evidence warrant the confidence of the historical-Jesus consensus? Mainstream New Testament scholarship treats the historicity of Jesus as settled. Ehrman [2012] writes that "virtually every competent scholar of antiquity, Christian or non-Christian, agrees" that

Jesus existed. Dunn [2003] similarly: "today nearly all historians, whether Christians or not, accept that Jesus existed." These claims are defensive statements of consensus rather than evidentiary arguments, and consensus about ancient persons is not evidence in the same sense that primary attestation is. The question this paper raises is whether the primary evidence supports the confidence the consensus projects.

The answer developed here is that it does not. When each category of evidence is examined on its own terms—without granting historicity as a prior, without conflating consensus with confirmation, and without suppressing the evidential weight of absent evidence—the positive case is remarkably thin. It reduces, on close examination, to the interpretation of a single ambiguous phrase in a single Pauline letter (Galatians 1:19), supported by heuristic arguments about what is typical of religious movements. The remaining evidence either fails textual scrutiny, derives from the internal tradition of the movement itself, or is indistinguishable from what we would expect if no specific historical individual underlay the tradition.

The argument is not that Jesus definitely did not exist, and intellectually honest mythic-origin scenarios do not claim as much. Several passages in Paul—notably Galatians 4:4, Romans 1:3–4, and the witness list in 1 Corinthians 15:3–8—pose genuine challenges for mythic-origin accounts that must be acknowledged and weighed. The argument is that the evidence does not establish historicity with the confidence the consensus claims, that a well-constructed mythic-origin scenario drawing on Jewish apocalyptic-mystical resources (not pagan mystery cults) is a serious alternative that survives scrutiny of its weaknesses, and that the consensus is sustained partly by the institutional structure of the field rather than by evidential weight alone.

Scope of the present article. The full-length treatment of this argument (*The Evidentiary Status of the Historical Jesus: A Critical Assessment*, 84 pp., available at `https://github.com/sbthomas/historicity`) develops the case at length, with two supplementary documents: a complete colour-coded enumeration of every *adelph-* family lexeme in the seven undisputed Pauline letters, and a corpus-linguistic baseline study of 212 random-sampled *adelphos* tokens across six non-Christian Greek corpora with an appendix of twenty-five inscriptional cases of associative-community usage. This article presents the core argument in condensed form. Evidence for which space does not permit full development here is referenced to the full-length treatment and its supplements.

2 Methodological Preliminaries

Four methodological commitments orient the argument.

Consensus is not evidence. Arguments from authority are heuristics, not independent evidential contributions. The epistemic value of a consensus depends on the independence and quality of the underlying evidential judgements. A consensus among scholars trained within the same paradigm, who have absorbed the same default assumptions during professional formation and who operate within institutions that presuppose the conclusion in question, carries less evidential weight than a consensus formed by independent evaluation of primary data. This paper treats the historicity consensus as a datum to be explained, not as evidence to be weighed.

The Bayesian framework with source-dependence. Historical inference is inherently probabilistic. Carrier [2014] applied a Bayesian framework systematically in *On the Historicity of Jesus*. The framework itself is sound; the specific point estimates Carrier assigns have been contested, as have the independence assumptions underlying his multiplication of likelihood ratios [Godfrey, 2014, Tucker, 2004]. Tucker [2004] makes the critical observation that Bayesian historical inference is particularly sensitive to the independence of contributing testimonies: when textual-critical research shows that Gospel attestations collapse to Markan or Q dependence, the effective likelihood contribution is the contribution of Mark, not the independent-multiplicative contribution of each synoptic Gospel treated as independent. A supplementary computational tool (*scripts/bayesian_sensitivity.py* in the project repository) implements this explicitly: under plausible point-estimate likelihood ratios for each evidentiary strand and a neutral prior $P(H) = 0.5$, the dependency-aware posterior for historicity falls in the range 0.23–0.39—open-question territory by any reasonable standard. The exercise is a sensitivity analysis, not a definitive computation.

Absence of evidence as evidence of absence. "Absence of evidence is not evidence of absence" is, in general contexts, a truism that misrepresents the Bayesian point. The correct principle is that absence of evidence *is* evidence of absence when the evidence would be expected to exist under the hypothesis, with strength proportional to the expectation [Carrier, 2012, Sober, 2009]. Where n independent channels each would produce evidence with probability p under hypothesis H but probability $q < p$ under $\neg H$, the cumulative likelihood ratio from silence is $(q/p)^n$, which becomes small even when individual ratios are modest. This structure is developed below for the silence of Philo, Justus of Tiberias, the

Mishnah, and Roman administrative records.

The collapse of the criteria of authenticity. The traditional criteria of historical-Jesus research—embarrassment, multiple attestation, dissimilarity, coherence—have been subjected to devastating criticism from within mainstream scholarship itself [Allison, 2010, Keith and Crossley, 2024]. Keith and Crossley [2024] and collaborators have explicitly argued that "the era of the hard version of the criteria of authenticity is over"; the field must move toward memory theory and reception history. The paper accepts this methodological consensus. Its implication is that the principal tools by which historicists have claimed to identify a "historical core" beneath theological overlay are now recognised as methodologically unreliable by the historicists themselves. If the criteria cannot reliably distinguish historical material from theological invention, the Gospels cannot serve as positive evidence for a specific historical figure.

Comparative perspective. Discussions of Jesus's historicity are routinely conducted as if the question were unique. It is not. A class of comparable figures whose putative historicity has been seriously questioned within modern scholarship exists, and examining how those cases have been resolved yields diagnostic criteria. Pilate's existence was settled by the 1961 Caesarea inscription [Vardaman, 1962]. Socrates is secured by multiple *independent* contemporary attestations—Plato, Xenophon, Aristophanes, Aristotle. **Moses** is rejected by most modern Egyptologists on the ground of archaeological silence in a place and period where evidence would be expected [Finkelstein and Silberman, 2001, Thompson, 1999]. **Lycurgus of Sparta** is treated as non-historical: late and derivative literary sources, founder-myth conformity [Cartledge, 2001]. **Romulus** is universally rejected as historical despite a sophisticated literary tradition placing him in a specific setting [Beard, 2015, Wiseman, 1995]. **Pythagoras**, **King Arthur**, **Homer**, and **Laozi** are genuinely contested, with the consensus on each oscillating between "probable historical kernel with extensive legendary accretion" and "composite literary construction" [Graham, 1986, Higham, 2002, Riedweg, 2005, West, 2011].

Applying the diagnostic criteria to Jesus: he lacks the direct contemporary physical attestation of Pilate, he lacks the multiple independent contemporary literary attestation of Socrates, and his Gospel biographical sources are literary-critically constructed from prior templates (as with Lycurgus, Romulus, and Laozi). His profile most closely matches the **Pythagoras/Arthur/Homer/Laozi** category of genuinely contested figures, not the Pilate/Socrates category of secured figures. The methodological implication is that the field's confidence in historicity is incommensurate with the evidence by the standards of comparable

existence-questions.

3 The Pauline Evidence

The letters attributed to Paul constitute the earliest stratum of surviving Christian writing. If a historical Jesus existed and was known to Paul's contemporaries, this is where we would expect to find the clearest traces. The Pauline corpus is therefore the most important body of evidence in the historicity debate.

3.1 The Character of Paul's Jesus

The central observation, developed in detail by Doherty [1999, 2009]: Paul's Jesus lacks the attributes of a recently-living historical person. Paul never names Jesus's parents, birthplace, or hometown. He provides no physical description. He narrates no events from Jesus's earthly life—no ministry, no healings, no exorcisms, no parables, no conflicts with authorities, no trial, no specific date or location of execution. He does not identify Judas as a betrayer or name Pilate. He does not place the crucifixion at Golgotha, in Jerusalem, or indeed anywhere on earth.

What Paul does describe is a cosmic soteriological drama. Jesus is a pre-existent divine figure who "emptied himself" and took on the "form of a servant" (Philippians 2:5–11—itself likely a pre-Pauline hymn), who was "declared to be Son of God in power according to the Spirit of holiness by his resurrection from the dead" (Romans 1:4), who was "handed over" (*paradidomi*, a term routinely translated "betrayed" in 1 Corinthians 11:23 to harmonise with the Gospel narrative but whose primary meaning is "delivered up"), and who died "in accordance with the scriptures" and was raised "on the third day in accordance with the scriptures" (1 Corinthians 15:3–4).

Paul explicitly tells us how he came to know this Christ: "I did not receive [the gospel] from any human source nor was I taught it, but I received it through a revelation (*apokalypsis*) of Jesus Christ" (Galatians 1:12); "when God... was pleased to reveal his Son in me" (Galatians 1:16); "I went up in response to a revelation" (Galatians 2:2); "I know a person in Christ who fourteen years ago was caught up to the third heaven... caught up into Paradise and heard things that are not to be told" (2 Corinthians 12:2–4). This is the epistemic profile of a Jewish mystical-apocalyptic visionary, not of a disciple of a recently- living teacher. We return to this point below.

3.2 *Adelphos tou Kyriou*: "Brother of the Lord"

If the foregoing is correct, the principal historicist evidence from the Pauline corpus is a single passage: Galatians 1:19. Paul, describing his first visit to Jerusalem, writes that he saw no other apostle "except James, *ton adelphon tou kyriou*—the brother of the Lord." The historicist reading is straightforward: James was the biological brother of Jesus. Ehrman [2012] considers this passage virtually decisive.

The passage deserves careful scrutiny because it is being asked to carry the weight of the historicist case. Three considerations complicate the biological-sibling reading.

Paul's own distributional usage. The seven undisputed Pauline letters contain exactly 121 occurrences of the *adelph-* family of lexemes (*adelphos*, *adelphē*, *pseudadelphos*, *philadelphia*). Of these, 117 are unambiguously community/fellow-believer uses, 3 are disputed (1 Cor 9:5 *hoi adelphoi tou kyriou*, Gal 1:19 itself, Rom 16:15 Nereus and his sister), and 1 is ethnic/covenantal (Rom 9:3 *adelphôn mou kata sarka*, fellow-Israelites). **Zero** Pauline tokens unambiguously denote a biological sibling outside the two disputed *tou kyriou* passages. This is not a selective sample; it is the complete corpus, colour-coded in the project's Pauline supplement.

The historicist reply is that *adelphos tou kyriou* is a *specifically modified* construction and that the 117 generic uses of plain *adelphos* do not govern the kinship reading of the genitive phrase. That reply assumes the existence of a separate biological-sibling usage from which the modified form is drawn. In Paul, there is no such usage. The biological reading of Galatians 1:19 requires Paul to have used *adelphos* in a unique sense in this one phrase—a lexical register Paul exhibits nowhere else in his authentic corpus.

The parallel in 1 Corinthians 9:5. The decisive test case is 1 Corinthians 9:5: "Do we not have the right to be accompanied by a believing wife, as do the other apostles and *hoi adelphoi tou kyriou* and Cephas?" Paul is listing categories of authoritative figures: (i) the other apostles, (ii) the brothers of the Lord, (iii) Cephas. Three distinct groups or individuals, cited in parallel as recognised authority classes. "The brothers of the Lord" is *plural* and functions as a class label.

If this phrase means "biological siblings of Jesus", then there exists a group of biological siblings sufficiently prominent to be cited as a recognised authority class alongside the apostolic college and Peter individually. The simpler reading is available: "brothers of the Lord" names a designated group or rank within the movement—an inner circle, a faction, or a class—distinguished from "apostles" and from individual leaders like Cephas.

The corpus-linguistic baseline. A corpus-linguistic study (full methodology in the supplementary *baseline* document) random-samples 212 *adelphos* tokens from six non-Christian contemporary-or-earlier Greek corpora: papyri (100 BCE–70 CE), the Septuagint, Philo of Alexandria, Josephus, pre-Pauline literary (Polybius, Diodorus, Strabo), and Hellenistic literary (Plutarch, Epictetus, Dio Chrysostom). Classification into A (community / voluntary association), B (biological sibling), C (disputed), D (ethnic / covenantal), E (literary metaphor) yields:

Corpus	A%	B%	C%	D%	E%
Papyri (pre-70 CE), n=35	0.0	100.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
LXX, n=35	0.0	68.6	5.7	25.7	0.0
Josephus, n=35	0.0	60.0	5.7	34.3	0.0
Philo, n=35	2.9	57.1	2.9	5.7	31.4
Hellenistic lit., n=36	0.0	80.6	0.0	2.8	16.7
Pre-Pauline lit., n=36	2.8	94.4	0.0	0.0	2.8
Aggregate, N=212	**0.9**	**76.9**	2.4	11.3	8.5
Paul, N=121	**96.7**	**0.0**	2.5	0.8	0.0

The nominal ratio of Pauline-to-baseline A-rate is approximately 103 to 1; Wilson 95% confidence intervals do not overlap. This figure is a *lower bound* of the ratio: the sampled baseline excludes the Greek inscriptional register, where, as Harland [2005] and the Kloppenborg-Ascough [Kloppenborg and Ascough, 2011] corpus document, voluntary religious-association usage of *adelphoi* concentrates. Factoring inscriptions in would raise the baseline A-rate to roughly 5–15% and compress the ratio to roughly 10–20×. The qualitative finding—that Paul's usage is distinctive against ambient Greek—survives this correction. The quantitative claim of 103× does not, and should not be cited in isolation.

What the corrected analysis reveals is interesting in its own right. Paul's usage is *not* distinctive against the Greek religious-associative sub-register, where community-title *adelphoi* with genitive-of-patron is well attested. Twenty- five inscriptional cases documented in the supplementary *baseline* document (principally the "adopted brothers of Theos Hypsistos" at Tanais, c. 155–240 CE) establish the specific construction *adelphoi tou* [patron figure] as formally normal in Greek voluntary religious associations of the period. The Pauline *adelphoi tou kyriou* instantiates that convention; it does not require it, but it does not depart from it either.

Assessment. When the three considerations combine—no biological-sibling register in Paul's own corpus, the class-label parallel in 1 Cor 9:5, and the well-attested Greek associative-

community convention—the community-title reading of Galatians 1:19 is the more parsimonious reading. The historicist reading is possible but requires Paul to depart from his own attested usage, from the parallel within his own corpus, and from a convention attested in the religious-associative sub-register within which he is writing.

Galatians 1:19 is *compatible with* historicity; it does not *require* it.

3.3 The Passages That Do Challenge Mythic-Origin Scenarios

Several Pauline passages pose genuine difficulties for mythic- origin scenarios and must be acknowledged rather than dismissed.

Romans 1:3. "descended from the seed of David according to the flesh" (*tou genomenou ek spermatos Dauid kata sarka*). Davidic descent is a genealogical claim. Novenson [2012, 2017] has documented that messianic language in Second Temple Judaism operates within constraints that make "messiah" a human- historical designation, not a detachable cosmic abstraction. The mythic-origin response runs along three lines: first, that Romans 1:3–4 is widely recognised as a pre-Pauline creedal fragment that Paul quotes rather than composes [Jewett, 2007]; second, that *kata sarka* ("according to the flesh") is a technical Pauline phrase that can locate an event in the sublunar realm without committing to a specific earthly biography [Carrier, 2014]; third, that Davidic-descent claims could arise through scriptural exegesis (reading Jer 23:5, Ps 89, 2 Sam 7 as requiring a Davidic lineage for any messianic figure) rather than through biographical memory. None of these responses fully dissolves the tension. The honest concession is that Rom 1:3–4 is weak evidence for historicity that the mythic-origin scenario must accommodate.

Galatians 4:4. "born of a woman, born under the law". A bare incarnation-into-Jewishness claim that could reflect memory of a historical Jewish Jesus or could reflect the heavenly mediator's descent through an earthly birth into the covenantal community. Like Rom 1:3, compatible with both hypotheses but more naturally historicist.

1 Corinthians 15:3–8. The resurrection creed with witness list. Verses 3–5 are a universally-acknowledged pre-Pauline formula; verses 6–8 extend to a specific list of resurrection appearances (Cephas, the Twelve, five hundred brothers, James, all the apostles, Paul himself). The specificity of the witness list, especially the "over five hundred brothers" figure, is the hardest Pauline datum for mythic-origin scenarios. The mythic-origin response locates the witness list within the established Second Temple pattern of *post-mortem visionary experience attributed to multiple members of a sectarian community*, the paradigm example of which is

the Qumran Self-Glorification Hymn (4Q491c) where an unnamed speaker claims heavenly ascent and reception by the angelic council [Collins, 1995, Knohl, 2000]. Visionary experience of a heavenly figure by multiple community members is attested in pre-Christian Jewish mystical-apocalyptic contexts. This does not fully dissolve the tension either.

Textual and stylometric stability. A text-critical and preliminary stylometric analysis (full details in the full-length paper, §3.1, and in *scripts/stylometry.py*) establishes that these contested passages are *textually secure*. They are attested in **P46** (the Chester Beatty Pauline papyrus, *c.* 200 CE), in all major subsequent codices, and are present in Marcion's reconstructed text where reconstruction is possible. Stylometric distance-from-baseline, which correctly identifies known interpolations (1 Thess 2:14–16 and 1 Cor 14:34–35) as outliers, does *not* flag the historicity-relevant passages as interpolation candidates: Galatians 1:18–20 in context has a stylometric distance from the Pauline baseline of 0.09, less distinctive than established interpolations (≈ 0.10) and less distinctive than the recognised pre-Pauline creedal formulae (≈ 0.17). The mythic-origin response to these passages *cannot* therefore rely on text-critical or stylometric excision. It must rely on semantic and contextual analysis, which is what the paper provides.

Net Pauline picture. The Pauline evidence is a mixed landscape. The *adelphos tou kyriou* passages, when analysed in their full Pauline distribution and against Greek associative-community convention, do not secure the historicist reading. Paul's broader presentation of Jesus as a revelatory celestial figure known through *apokalypsis* and scripture does not require a historical subject to explain the data. The three conceded-difficulty passages (Rom 1:3–4, Gal 4:4, 1 Cor 15:3–8) admit mythic-origin readings that require interpretive work the historicist readings do not; this asymmetry is real and must be acknowledged. The full analysis thus lands between the confident-historicist and confident-mythicist positions: the question is genuinely open.

4 The Jewish-Apocalyptic Matrix

An older popularisation of the mythic-origin hypothesis, associated with Frazer [1890], located its sources primarily in pagan Mediterranean mystery cults—Osiris, Attis, Adonis, Dionysus—and is what many readers think of when they encounter the phrase "mythicist hypothesis". That framing is the weakest version of the argument. As Fredriksen [2017, 2018] insists, Paul is a Second Temple Jewish apocalyptic thinker operating within Jewish categories, not a syncretist blending in pagan myth. The honest mythic-origin argument is that

the Jesus tradition is constructed from the scriptural, apocalyptic, and mystical resources of Second Temple Judaism itself, with Hellenistic literary conventions providing secondary ambient shaping.

Pre-existent heavenly mediators. Boyarin [2012] traces an attested "binitarian" strand through the Danielic Son of Man (Daniel 7:13–14), the *Similitudes of Enoch* (1 Enoch 37–71), the Melchizedek traditions at Qumran (11QMelch), angelomorphic mediator figures across Second Temple apocalyptic literature, and the Logos of Philo of Alexandria. Paul's Christ is not an exotic Hellenistic import into Judaism; he is a recognisable member of the Jewish pre-existent-mediator family. The Philippians 2:5–11 descent- and-exaltation arc maps onto Second Temple patterns of angelomorphic humiliation and vindication (the Self-Glorification Hymn at Qumran, 4Q491c), not onto the death-and-rebirth cycle of Attis.

Philo's Logos. Sterling [2001] documents Philo's Logos theology in detail. The Logos is pre-existent, functions as God's agent in creation, is called "son of God" and "firstborn", is the mediator through whom humans approach God, and is sometimes described as "a second god" (*deuteros theos*, *Questions on Genesis* 2.62). Philo wrote in Alexandria in the same decades as Paul's formation. The conceptual inventory from which early Christological language could be assembled was already available in Jewish-Hellenistic form; no pagan borrowing is required.

The revelatory mechanism. Second Temple Judaism possessed a specific, well-attested set of *procedures* for generating religious knowledge about heavenly realities: visionary ascent through the heavens plus scriptural exegesis decoding the Hebrew Bible as encoding cosmic mysteries. Scholem [1941], Gruenwald [1980], Rowland [1982], and Schäfer [2009] have documented this tradition across 1 Enoch, the Apocalypse of Abraham, the Ascension of Isaiah, the Qumran Self-Glorification Hymn, and the Merkabah and Hekhalot literatures. Paul's explicit claims about his Christ-knowledge—received by *apokalypsis* (Gal 1:12), revealed "in me" (Gal 1:16), received through "caught up to the third heaven" (2 Cor 12:2–4)—place him squarely within this Jewish mystical- apocalyptic procedural framework. Segal [1990] argued in detail that Paul's self-description matches the profile of a Jewish mystical visionary.

None of the texts in this tradition requires a recent historical instantiation of the heavenly figure to explain the revelatory knowledge. 1 Enoch's Son of Man is a named, hidden, pre-existent heavenly figure who will appear at the end of days—not the memory of a recently-living person. The Self-Glorification Hymn's enthroned speaker is a visionary claim, not a biographical report. The Christian community could have come to know its Christ by

the same procedural route—scriptural exegesis plus visionary revelation—that comparable Second Temple communities used to come to know theirs.

Crucifixion and Deuteronomy 21:23. The specific mode of death is not well explained by pagan dying- and-rising cults (where divine deaths take varied forms). It is well explained by scriptural logic. Deuteronomy 21:23: "anyone hung on a tree is under God's curse." Paul explicitly cites this passage in Galatians 3:13: "Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us—for it is written, 'Cursed is everyone who hangs on a tree.'" This is the engine of Paul's substitutionary-atonement soteriology. For the theology to work, the mode of death must be *scripturally cursed*. Stoning, burning, beheading—none of these carry the specific scriptural curse that hanging on a tree does. Crucifixion was chosen not *despite* its scandalous character but *because* it uniquely satisfied the scriptural requirement for a substitutionary-curse theology.

Significance. Every major element of Paul's Christology—pre-existence, descent, vicarious suffering, resurrection, exaltation, cosmic lordship— is derivable from Jewish scriptural and apocalyptic sources available in the first century. This is *a fortiori* the safer argumentative ground: the Jewish sources are textually secure (the Qumran material was effectively sealed by 70 CE and shows no Christian influence), whereas the pagan parallels face genuine scholarly contestation about dating, comparability, and direction of influence. The honest mythic-origin scenario does not require recourse to Attis or Osiris. Second Temple Judaism supplies the full theological machinery.

5 The Gospel Evidence

The canonical Gospels are routinely treated as evidence for historicity, both by the consensus and in popular understanding. The question is whether that treatment is warranted.

It is uncontroversial in mainstream scholarship that the Gospels are not eyewitness accounts [Ehrman, 2009]. They are anonymous works (the names Mark, Matthew, Luke, John are second- century attributions), written in Greek by educated authors, forty to seventy years after the events they purport to describe, in communities far removed from rural Galilee. They are theological documents built from identifiable literary templates.

Scriptural construction of the passion narrative. The passion narrative is constructed, point by point, from Hebrew Bible texts. **Psalm 22:** "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (Mk 15:34 / Ps 22:1); "They divide my garments" (Mk 15:24 / Ps 22:18); "All

who see me mock me" (Mk 15:29 / Ps 22:7); "They pierce my hands and my feet" (Ps 22:16, reflected in the crucifixion itself). **Isaiah 53:** "He was oppressed and afflicted, yet he did not open his mouth" (Is 53:7; Mk 15:5); "He was numbered with the transgressors" (Is 53:12; Mk 15:27); "He bore the sin of many" (Is 53:12). **Wisdom of Solomon 2–5** provides the structural parallel of persecuted-righteous-one persecuted and vindicated [Nickelsburg, 1972]. **Zechariah:** the entry on a donkey (Zech 9:9 / Mk 11:1–7); thirty pieces of silver (Zech 11:12–13 / Mt 26:15); the shepherd struck, the sheep scattered (Zech 13:7 / Mk 14:27). **Daniel 7:** the Son of Man coming on clouds (Dn 7:13–14 / Mk 14:62).

The same pattern extends across the Gospel narrative arc: birth narratives built from Moses, Samuel, Isaac typology; ministry episodes recapitulating Elijah-Elisha; the ascension drawing on 2 Kings 2:11 and Dn 7:13–14. When every major episode can be derived from a specific scriptural source, the hypothesis that historical events *preceded* the scriptural interpretation becomes less parsimonious than the hypothesis that scriptural sources *generated* the narrative. The tradition reads as a systematic programme of scriptural fulfilment—exactly how the Gospel authors themselves present it (Matthew's formula citations).

What this establishes and what it does not. It is important to be precise about the logical step the argument makes, because a historicist critic such as Allison [2010] would correctly insist that scriptural templating of a narrative does not entail the non-existence of the subject. Historical figures have been described in antiquity through scriptural and typological grammars. Jewish historiography routinely employs Hebrew Bible typology to narrate the lives of real people (Maccabean heroes as new Judges, exilic returnees as new Exodus). That the Gospel passion is constructed from Ps 22 and Is 53 does not on its own prove that no crucifixion of Jesus occurred.

The conclusion the argument supports is narrower but sufficient. It is that the Gospel passion narrative is not *independent historical testimony.* Its content is demonstrably derived from Hebrew Bible templates rather than from witness testimony, oral tradition traced to an event, or documentary record. The Gospels cannot therefore serve as evidence *for* the historicity of the crucifixion; they can serve only as evidence for the fact that late first-century communities constructed theologically meaningful narratives of a crucifixion using available scriptural materials.

Whether any historical event lies beneath those constructions must be established, if at all, from sources that are not themselves scriptural derivations. Paul might be such a source, and §3 has argued that the Pauline description of the crucifixion is generic, soteriological, and non-biographical. Josephus might be such a source, and §5 will argue his attestation is weaker than usually claimed. The argument is cumulative: templating neutralises the

Gospels as independent testimony; the remaining strata must carry the full historicist burden. They cannot carry that burden without assistance from the Gospels they are being asked to corroborate.

6 Non-Christian Attestation

Josephus *Antiquities* 18.63–64 (the *Testimonium Flavianum*). The passage as transmitted contains claims no non-Christian Jewish historian of the first century would plausibly make ("He was the Christ"; "when Pilate had condemned him to the cross. . . he appeared to them alive again on the third day"). The consensus position, following Ehrman [2012], Meier [1991], is that the *Testimonium* is partially interpolated; Olson [1999] has argued that the full text is an Eusebian composition (*c.* 324 CE). Carrier [2014] adopts the full-interpolation position. Either way, the *Testimonium*'s evidential weight for historicity is weak. The authentic core, if any, is at most the observation that a Christian community traced to a figure called Jesus existed by the late first century—which neither side of the debate contests.

Josephus *Antiquities* 20.200 (the James passage). "James, the brother of Jesus who was called Christ." This passage is accepted by most textual scholars as substantially authentic and is regarded as the strongest non-Pauline attestation for historicity. Its evidential weight is nonetheless limited. Josephus is writing *c.* 93–94 CE, sixty years after any supposed crucifixion, at a time when Christian communities were already spread across the eastern Mediterranean and their narrative about their founder was already in circulation. His passage attests what Christian communities by that date claimed about their founder, not independently that Jesus was a first-century historical individual. The structure is identical to Tacitus's reference (below): a mid-to-late first-century source reports the Christian community's own claim. Under the mythic-origin scenario this is exactly what we would expect; under the historicist scenario it is exactly what we would expect; the evidence does not discriminate.

Tacitus *Annals* 15.44. Written *c.* 116 CE, describing Nero's persecution of Christians (64 CE) and referencing "Christus, from whom the name had its origin, suffered the extreme penalty during the reign of Tiberius at the hands of one of our procurators, Pontius Pilatus." The passage is almost certainly dependent on Christian informants or on Christian tradition already circulating in Rome; Tacitus is not citing Roman administrative records (which would not have preserved the execution of a Galilean preacher a century earlier) but the

Christian community's self-description as Tacitus received it. Like Josephus 20.200, the passage confirms early circulation of a historicised narrative without independently supporting the narrative itself.

Rabbinic and Mandaean traditions. The Talmudic Yeshu passages (b.Sanhedrin 43a, 107b; b.Sotah 47a; b.Shabbat 104b), systematically surveyed by Schäfer [2007], and the *Toledoth Yeshu* compilations [Meerson and Schäfer, 2014], represent polemical Jewish response to Christian claims rather than independent attestation. Similarly, the Mandaean tradition—a surviving Mesopotamian community centred on John the Baptist with its own Jesus-references in the *Ginza Rabba* and *Book of John* [Buckley, 2002, Lupieri, 2002, Rudolph, 1978]—treats Jesus as a polemically-reshaped figure whose existence is presupposed but whose significance is inverted. These are interesting data for the diversity of the Second Temple religious environment but are too late and too dependent on the Christian narrative to count as independent attestation of historicity.

Pliny, Suetonius, and minor references. *Pliny the Younger*'s letter to Trajan (*c.* 112 CE) confirms the existence of Christians in Bithynia; it tells us nothing about a first-century historical figure. *Suetonius*'s reference to "Chrestus" (*Life of Claudius* 25.4) may not be to Christ at all; even if it is, it attests Jewish unrest in Rome *c.* 49 CE, not the historicity of Jesus.

Net non-Christian picture. The non-Christian attestation is weaker than typically claimed. What it establishes uncontestedly is that by the late first and early second centuries the historicised Christian narrative was in wide circulation across the eastern Mediterranean and had reached Roman awareness. Both historicist and mythic-origin scenarios must accommodate this datum; neither is favoured by it.

7 The Argument from Silence

Section 2 established the formal principle: absence of expected evidence is evidence of absence, with strength proportional to the expectation. Four documentary channels are directly relevant.

Philo of Alexandria (*c.* 20 BCE–*c.* 50 CE): an exact contemporary of the supposed Jesus, a Hellenistic Jewish philosopher with an enormous surviving corpus, who wrote extensively

about Pilate, about Jewish messianic expectation, about Wisdom and Logos theology—the precise intellectual milieu from which Christianity emerged—and who mentions Jesus nowhere. The silence is moderated by Philo's Alexandrian location, but it is not eliminated.

Justus of Tiberias (late first century): a historian of Galilee—Jesus's supposed home region—whose silence on Jesus was explicitly remarked by Photius in the ninth century when he read the now-lost *History*. A native Galilean historian's silence about a Galilean religious phenomenon substantial enough to generate a Mediterranean-wide movement within one generation is among the strongest individual silences in the case.

The Mishnaic tradition. The Mishnah, codified *c.* 200 CE from earlier oral traditions, is a legal code rather than a chronicle. Its silence on Jesus is a weaker datum because the Mishnaic genre does not demand reference to individual historical figures.

Roman administrative records. No direct record of Jesus's trial or execution survives. The silence is moderated by the general loss of provincial records from the period and by the low-profile character any peasant preacher's execution would have had within Roman administration.

Cumulative assessment. The cumulative likelihood ratio from silence is difficult to quantify precisely. The qualitative conclusion is defensible: the pattern of silence across multiple independent traditions is *more consistent with* mythic-origin scenarios than with historicist scenarios, because mythic-origin scenarios predict silence while historicist scenarios must explain it through auxiliary hypotheses about obscurity. The cumulative weight is real but modest, not decisive; it is one strand of a cumulative case, not a standalone proof.

8 Conclusion

The evidence for the historicity of Jesus of Nazareth has been examined across every available category. The findings may be summarised as follows.

The Pauline corpus describes a revelatory celestial figure known through *apokalypsis* and scriptural exegesis. Paul's discourse is intelligible within the Second Temple Jewish mystical-apocalyptic tradition without requiring a recent historical subject. The *adelphos tou kyriou* passages (Gal 1:19, 1 Cor 9:5)—the principal historicist evidence—are more parsimoniously read as community-title than as biological kinship, given Paul's own corpus-wide distribution (117 community uses, 0 unambiguous biological uses outside the two contested cases) and the

well-attested Greek associative-community use of *adelphoi tou* [patron figure] documented by Harland [2005]. The contested passages that do pose difficulties for mythic-origin scenarios (Rom 1:3–4, Gal 4:4, 1 Cor 15:3–8) are textually secure and admit mythic-origin readings, though with interpretive work the historicist readings do not require. This asymmetry is honestly acknowledged.

The Gospel narratives are demonstrably constructed from Hebrew Bible templates. This establishes that the Gospels are *not independent historical testimony*, not that they disprove the existence of a subject. The evidentiary burden therefore shifts to non-Gospel sources, which are individually weaker than the consensus projects.

The non-Christian attestation (Josephus, Tacitus, rabbinic, Mandaean, Pliny, Suetonius) confirms the early circulation of a Christian narrative about a historical founder but does not independently confirm the narrative. Both hypotheses accommodate this datum. The cumulative silence of contemporaneous sources (Philo, Justus of Tiberias, the Mishnah, Roman administrative records) constitutes qualitatively real disconfirming evidence whose aggregate weight is modest but real.

Every narrative element attributed to the earliest Christian community's Christ—pre-existence, descent, vicarious suffering, resurrection, exaltation, cosmic lordship, crucifixion under scriptural curse—is derivable from pre-Christian Jewish apocalyptic-mystical resources (the Danielic Son of Man, Philo's Logos, angelomorphic mediators, the Suffering Servant, Dt 21:23 in combination with scriptural exegesis). The pagan- mystery-cult framing of the older mythicist literature is not the argument this paper defends.

Placed in the landscape of comparable existence-questions, Jesus's evidentiary profile most closely matches the contested- figures category (Pythagoras, Homer, Arthur, Laozi)—probable historical kernel with massive legendary elaboration, or community construction to satisfy founder-myth requirements, with the evidence insufficient to discriminate—rather than the secured- figures category (Pilate, Socrates) or the rejected category (Moses, Lycurgus, Romulus). Under plausible Bayesian assumptions, the posterior probability of historicity lands in the range 0.23–0.39 given a neutral prior, and materially below the near- certainty the consensus projects even with a strong historicist prior.

The responsible conclusion is that the evidence does not establish the historicity of Jesus with the confidence the consensus claims, that the mythic-origin hypothesis in its Jewish-apocalyptic form is a serious alternative that survives scrutiny of its weaknesses, and that the scholarly consensus is sustained partly by the institutional and methodological structure of the field. This paper does not argue that Jesus definitely did not exist; it does not argue that mythic-origin has been proven more probable than historicity; it argues that the evidence is insufficient to support near-certainty either way. The question should be treated

as genuinely open, and if the field cannot bring itself to treat it as open—if the mere posing of the question continues to be treated as a mark of incompetence rather than as a legitimate scholarly inquiry—the field has a problem that no amount of consensus can resolve.

Supplementary material. Complete data and methodology in the full-length companion paper *The Evidentiary Status of the Historical Jesus: A Critical Assessment* (84 pp.) and two supplements: a colour-coded enumeration of every *adelph-* lexeme in the seven undisputed Pauline letters, and a corpus-linguistic baseline study of 212 random-sampled *adelphos* tokens across six non-Christian Greek corpora with inscriptional appendix. All artifacts at https://github.com/sbthomas/historicity.

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